

The Race Is Closer Than You Think

If you are looking to develop an AR app for consumer use or for your business, you will find that both platforms are up for the task, and very capably so. The subtle differences in both of them come down to deciding commercial dynamics more than their technical capacities.

Given that Apple follows a vertical structure, ARKit has the advantage of greater exposure and reach. Android, on the other hand, has what can be best described as a fragmented market share, which is why most of their phones and tablets will work on OS that has not necessarily been updated as well. Apple will typically ensure that its devices are running on the latest OS version.

Let's cut to the chase. You will, in all probability, be unlikely to find yourself deciding between the two solely on the basis of merit. The reason being that to build an app for Apple users you will need ARKit and for Android you will need ARCore. The two cannot be interchanged with each other. Therefore, it will not be shocking to see a host of developers work with both tools or substituting one of them with an entirely different SDK for their own reasons. This scenario will fail only in a case where you decide to exclusively make apps for only one of the two mobile operating systems.

In their current stages, there isn't much to set the two platforms apart. But as time goes by and more updates are added to the mix, one of the two tech giants might come out as a clear forerunner. Until then, it is anyone's game!

Taking A Slight Tangent

Consider this segment of this chapter as some food for thought. Donald Norman, an evolutionary writer wrote in his groundbreaking book 'The Invisible Computer' (1998) that computers are separate chunks of hardware and hence are difficult to use. They do not seem like a natural part of our environment. While laptops and notebooks today are becoming slimmer and portable, they are still separate objects that need persistent care. Norman argued that for computers to be truly useful, they should be invisible - a natural part of all other objects that we interact with in the real-world environment that we do not even notice the computers being involved.

While AR on your handheld devices is a definite step in that direction, it is but a small one. You still need to carry a device and keep tapping virtual objects by tapping and sliding your fingers around on a screen. If there comes a time when you can just reach out with your hands and accomplish